RESEARCH BRIEF · PROGRAMMATIC JOB HUNTING

Job Search Methodology & File Organization

What 2025–2026 evidence says about running a job search as a measurable pipeline — and how to organize the results so every posting, follow-up, and conversion rate lives in files that survive.

FISI Toolkit · Research 3-a

Erlangen · 50 km region · October 2026

TASK 21 · PERFECT FILES EDITION

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RESEARCH BRIEF · OCTOBER 2026

1. Executive Summary

This report condenses an internet research sweep on two questions asked together: how should a job search actually be run, and how should its results be organized so that the saved files become a durable asset rather than a pile of exports. The evidence base is ten targeted web searches and three full-page source reads, captured under *research/3-a/* in the project repository on 15 October 2026. Every quantitative claim in the pages that follow traces back to a named source in that folder.

The research converges on one framing: a job search is a funnel, and the funnel should be operated like a measurable pipeline rather than an act of patience. Candidate-side trackers, recruiter-side hiring funnels, and data-driven search guides all describe the same stages - discover, shortlist, apply, interview, offer - and all recommend computing conversion rates per stage so that effort goes to the stage that is actually leaking. The base rates are unforgiving: roughly 32 applications and four interviews stand behind every offer, which is precisely why untracked searching feels like noise.

41%	68.5 d	250	97.4%
of applications arrive within 48 h of posting (St. Louis Fed)	median time to first offer, 2025 (Interview Guys)	resumes per posting on average	of Fortune 500 screen via an ATS first

On the organization half, the authoritative file-management literature (CESSDA and the UK Data Service, plus university records-management practice) gives rules that map cleanly onto this project: dates in YYYY-MM-DD, hyphen-separated elements, folders over name-only conventions, stable pointers for current files, and README documentation as part of the structure. Task 21 implements both halves in the repository: the *download/* tree is reorganized into a documented layout maintained by an idempotent archiver, and a pre-seeded application tracker with live funnel formulas ships in *download/tracker/*.

METHODOLOGY · STAGES AND BASE RATES

2. The Funnel Model

A job search funnel is defined by Cruit as a structured system that tracks every stage of the search, from first discovering a company to signing an offer, modeled like a sales pipeline: many opportunities enter at the top, the best ones convert at the bottom. The model breaks the search into three macro-stages - visibility (getting in front of hiring managers), engagement (turning interest into conversations), and closing (converting interviews into offers). The practical value of the framing is diagnostic: knowing which stage is leaking tells you which problem to fix, instead of guessing whether the resume, the market,

or the interview performance is at fault.

The recruiter side runs a mirror funnel - sourced, contacted, responded, screened, submitted, interviewed, offered - and practitioner advice on r/recruiting is to keep it simple but always track conversion by stage. That advice transfers directly to the candidate side. Select Software Reviews' 2025 analysis found that 97.4 percent of Fortune 500 companies run an applicant tracking system, meaning most applications are machine-filtered before a human reads anything; visibility is a numbers problem before it is a charm problem.

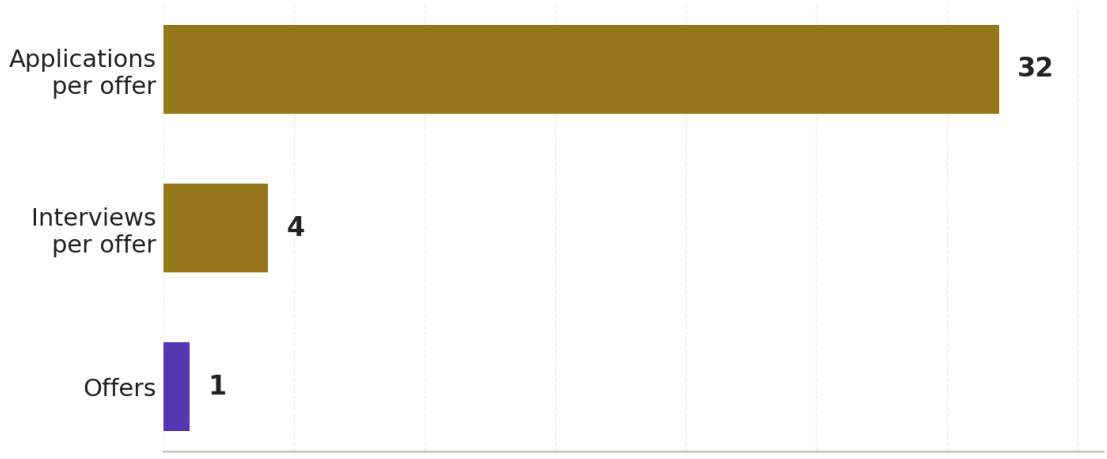


Figure 1 - Funnel base rates per one offer, 2025 averages (The Interview Guys, via askcruit.com).

The stage vocabulary below is the one implemented in the project's application tracker. It merges the candidate-side conventions of Teal and Huntr with the recruiting-funnel stages, and it is kept deliberately short: every extra stage is one more field a tired human will not update.

Stage	Meaning	Owner action
discovered	Pulled by the pipeline, not yet reviewed	Friday review: shortlist or close
shortlisted	Worth a tailored application	Spend the 3-5 h tailoring budget here
applied	Application sent	followup_due auto-fills at +7 days
interviewing	Any human contact scheduled or held	Log notes and contact person
offer	Offer in hand	Negotiate; everything before was cost
closed / rejected	Withdrawn, role died, or declined	Keep for conversion arithmetic

Table 1 - Status vocabulary of the application funnel.

METHODOLOGY · FRESHNESS

3. Timing: The 48-Hour Window

The cleanest timing evidence comes from the St. Louis Fed's analysis of application arrival times: 41 percent of all applications for a posting arrive within the first 48 hours, and 56 percent within 96 hours. Everyone competes in the same fresh window. Sources disagree on the size of the edge inside it - one claims applicants in the first 48 hours are four to five times more likely to get an interview request, others cite a 30 percent higher response rate, a third a 32 percent callback boost within 24 hours - but the direction is consistent across five independent sources, and even the most conservative reading puts early applicants ahead.

Day and time matter secondarily: applications sent Tuesday through Thursday mornings (8-11 AM) show roughly 30 percent higher response rates than other slots in metaintro's 2026 guide, with multiple sources agreeing mid-week beats Friday afternoon. For this project the implication is structural rather than behavioral: the daily pull cadence is already correct, and the pipeline's digest already flags rows that are new since yesterday. The tracker's *first_seen* column carries the freshness signal forward, so a shortlisting decision made on day three is visibly different from one made on day thirteen.

Window	Evidence	Action
First 24-48 h	41% of competition applies here (St. Louis Fed); response-rate edge of 30-32% reported by three sources	Review pipeline output daily; shortlist fast
Day 3-14	56% of applications in by 96 h; odds decay after	Second-chance review before rows age out of the 14-day window
Tue-Thu, 8-11 AM	~30% higher response (metaintro 2026)	Send tailored applications and follow-ups mid-week mornings
Friday afternoon	Weakest slot per multiple sources	Use for the review itself, not sends

Table 2 - Application-timing windows and the corresponding actions.

METHODOLOGY · AFTER THE SEND

4. The Follow-Up Cadence

Follow-up is the cheapest lever in the whole funnel and the first one people forget. The consensus across Indeed, Handshake, LinkedIn career-advice posts, and Frontline Source Group is to wait one week - five to seven business days - after applying, then send one polite follow-up; ten to fourteen days remains acceptable for slower processes. The purpose is dual: it reminds the hiring manager the application exists, and it restates interest while the requisition is still open. Multiple sources recommend sending mid-week, consistent with the timing table above.

After an interview the rhythm compresses: a thank-you note within 24 hours, a checking-in note after about a week, and only then a second follow-up a few days later (The Muse). None of this happens reliably by memory once more than a handful of applications are live - which is exactly the argument the tracker research makes. In the shipped tracker the *followup_due* column is a live formula: the moment a row's status becomes *applied* and an applied date exists, the due date auto-fills at plus seven days, and the Funnel sheet counts overdue follow-ups against today's date, turning the etiquette rule into a zero-memory checklist.

Situation	Wait	Move
After applying	5-7 business days	One polite follow-up email, mid-week
Still silent at 10-14 days	10-14 days total	Second contact acceptable; then close it
After interview	Within 24 h	Thank-you note to every interviewer
Post-interview silence	~1 week	Checking-in note; second follow-up a few days later

Table 3 - Follow-up cadence, aggregated from Indeed, The Muse, Handshake, and Frontline Source Group.

PERFECT FILES · CONVENTIONS

5. Organizing Results: File Architecture

The file-management literature is unusually concrete. The CESSDA Data Management Expert Guide, transmitting UK Data Service best practice, treats the file name as the principal identifier: it should describe content, carry status and version, and sort correctly. Its rules - dates in YYYY-MM-DD, elements separated by hyphens or underscores, no spaces or special characters, meaningful but brief names, extensions reserved for the format - are exactly the convention this project's generated files already follow. University records-management guidance (University of Washington) adds the structural

point: folder hierarchies are the stronger, more foolproof organization method, while name-only conventions demand ongoing discipline that humans rarely sustain.

Applied to the project, the redesign separates three kinds of files. Stable pointers (*jobs_latest.csv/json*) keep fixed names and are overwritten by every pipeline run, so humans and scripts always have one canonical current address. Immutable history lives in dated folders (*daily/YYYY-MM-DD/*) that are never edited in place - corrected re-runs land as new timestamped files beside the originals. Partition-by-kind containers (*reports/, tracker/, archive/*) keep the root minimal. The layout is maintained by *scripts/organize_downloads.py*, an idempotent archiver that classifies every root file, never overwrites, and is wired into the daily pipeline as step 5 of 6 - automating the maintenance that name-only conventions expect people to remember. Thirty-five previously flat files were organized on adoption day.

Path	Role	Rules
download/jobs_latest.*	Stable pointers	Fixed names, overwritten each run, never moved
download/daily/YYYY-MM-DD/	Immutable run history	Timestamped CSV/JSON/rejected files; never edited in place
download/reports/	Generated documents	PDF reports, XLSX workbooks, cover sources
download/tracker/	The funnel file	Application tracker XLSX + CSV twin, committed to git
download/archive/	Legacy one-offs	Kept for history, excluded from the daily flow
download/README.md	The runbook	Documents the layout and the Friday protocol

Table 4 - The reorganized download/ layout.

PERFECT FILES · THE FUNNEL FILE

6. The Application Tracker

Tracker design advice is remarkably consistent across eztrackr, BeamJobs, Indeed, and the Reddit template threads. The spreadsheet is the external brain: it answers "did I already apply here?", it holds follow-up promises, and after a few weeks it starts producing strategic insights - which resume version gets callbacks, which boards send quality leads, where effort actually pays. The status column is called out as the MVP: a one-glance command center that only means something if it is updated, which is why the stage list is short and the Friday review exists. One row per posting, keyed by a hash of the posting URL, prevents the classic double-application mistake.

The tracker shipped with this task implements the researched column set and seeds it from the 2026-10-14 pipeline run: 46 postings, each with company, role, city, source, transit class, first-seen date,

and a stable URL hash. Status is a validated dropdown; the applied-date field drives the follow-up formula; a one-to-five fit score marks the shortlist. Two design choices follow the portability argument in the tool-comparison literature: the file is a plain XLSX with a CSV twin - no subscription, no lock-in, formats that outlive any vendor - and the workbook is committed to git on every change, the same durability rule the mail-channel escrow follows.

Column group	Columns	Purpose
Identity	id, company, role, city, url	Dedupe by URL hash; one row per posting
Provenance	source, transit, first_seen	Source-yield analytics; freshness tracking
Status (MVP)	status	Funnel stage; validated dropdown, conditional colors
Dates	applied_date, followup_due	Cadence made executable (+7 d formula)
Priority	fit	1-5; the tailoring budget goes to the top rows
Materials	notes	Contact person, resume version, outcome notes

Table 5 - Tracker columns and their rationale (research/3-a B2).

METHODOLOGY · CLOSING THE SYSTEM

7. The Friday Review Loop

The data-driven search guides agree on the operating cadence: review the tracker weekly, read conversion by stage and by source, and shift effort toward what produces interviews. Resumly's analytics guide recommends exporting the tracker every Friday and adjusting keywords or target companies from what the numbers say; LinkedIn's tracking guide says the same in plainer words - spot trends, understand what works, move effort. Without this loop the tracker is a diary; with it, the funnel becomes a feedback system.

The Funnel sheet in the shipped workbook computes the review automatically: stage counts, the two conversion benchmarks (applied-to-interview at roughly 12 percent per the base rates, interview-to-offer around one in four), overdue follow-ups against today's date, and per-source yield as rows, active rows, and shortlisted rows. The ten-minute Friday protocol, documented in both the workbook's Playbook sheet and the download README: clear overdue follow-ups first; review every discovered row and either shortlist or close it, never let them pile; read the two conversion rates and act on the leaking stage, not the loudest problem; demote any source with zero shortlisted rows after three weeks; then commit the tracker to git. The commit step matters more than it looks - the tracker is the only file in the system whose history

cannot be regenerated from the pipeline database.

CALIBRATION · THE LOCAL MARKET

8. Germany Junior-IT Reality Check

One r/Germany_Jobs post documents a complete junior IT search with unusual honesty: eleven months, 12.5 applications per month at 40-60 minutes each, five interviews (7.1 percent of applications), three of the five killed at the HR screen, and finally an offer. The arithmetic matches the international base rates almost exactly, which is reassuring: the funnel math is not American folklore, it holds in the German market. The same thread's comment section and the Germany-specific guides converge on 3-6 months as a normal search duration, and on 3-5 hours per tailored application when the Anschreiben is written properly.

11 mo	12.5	7.1%	3-6 mo
logged duration of a real junior IT search	applications per month sustained	application-to-interview rate achieved	considered normal in Germany (niv-now)

The strategic implication for this project is the division of labor the architecture already encodes. The pipeline does the volume work - seventeen sources, hard filters for full-time roles without Ausbildung requirements, a 50-kilometer transit-feasibility ring, a fourteen-day window - so the human tailoring budget of 3-5 hours per application is spent only on shortlisted rows rather than sprayed across a hundred portals. The tracker then measures whether that budget converts. Quality-over-quantity advice (Forbes 2025) and the German volume reality are not in conflict: the correct synthesis is qualified volume, a hard-filtered feed feeding a deliberately small shortlist.

IMPLEMENTATION MAP · TASK 21

9. Gap Analysis: What the Toolkit Covers

The research lands on a project that already implements roughly half of it. The naming convention, source attribution, daily cadence, hard filters, and backup regime predate this task; the funnel tracker, the follow-up automation, the documented file layout, and the weekly-review instrumentation are new. The table below records the mapping, including what changed in Task 21 and what remains deliberately open.

Research recommendation	Status before	Task 21 action
Track stages, compute conversion (A1-A2)	Job memory tracked postings seen, not a funnel	Tracker XLSX+CSV with status funnel, pre-seeded (46 rows)
Apply inside 48 h (A3)	Daily cadence existed; freshness not surfaced	first_seen column + digest new-flags carried into tracker
Follow up at 5-7 business days (A4)	Nothing	followup_due formula + overdue counter on Funnel sheet
Weekly Friday review (A5)	Nothing scheduled	Funnel metrics sheet + protocol in Playbook and README
YYYY-MM-DD names, no special chars (B1)	Already compliant	Convention documented in download README
Folders by date/kind + pointers (B3)	Gap: 35 files flat at root, 1-line README	daily/, reports/, tracker/, archive/ + idempotent organizer wired into the pipeline
Source attribution (B5)	Already: source column everywhere	Feeds Funnel sheet yield table
Long-horizon durability (B4)	Git bundles v1-v8	Tracker committed to git on every change

Table 6 - Research recommendations mapped to toolkit status (A/B references point to research/3-a/findings.md).

Two gaps remain open on purpose. The durable x0.at mirror for large backup bundles is still blocked by a datacenter IP ban and needs a residential-IP retry, unchanged from the Task 20 note. And the tracker itself is a discipline, not a daemon: the pipeline can fill it every morning, but only the Friday review turns rows into decisions. The evidence says that review is where the search is actually won - everything else in this report is scaffolding for it.

Sources: St. Louis Fed On the Economy (2017); The Interview Guys 2025 via askcruit.com; Select Software Reviews 2025; eztrackr.app (2025); CESSDA DMEG / UK Data Service; University of Washington Records Management; metaintro (2026); Indeed, The Muse, Handshake, Frontline Source Group; r/Germany_Jobs; niv-now.com; germanycareercoach.com; Forbes (2025). Full evidence trail with URLs in research/3-a/findings.md and raw captures in research/3-a/raw/.